Pre-Class Assignment: Autor & Thompson Essay

"Beyond Job Displacement"

ECON 470 — Microeconomics of Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2026

Reading: David Autor and Neil Thompson, "Beyond Job Displacement: How AI Could Reshape the Value of Human Expertise," *The Digitalist Papers*, Vol. 2 (2024). Available at digitalistpapers.com/vol2/autorthompson.

Due: In person, TBD, at the start of class.

Instructions: Answer each question in 1–3 sentences. These are reading-check questions — they should be quick if you read the essay. You must submit this assignment in person. The assignment must be handwritten. No photocopies will be accepted.

Why we do this: A team of your classmates is presenting this essay and leading a 10-minute discussion afterward. These questions ensure you arrive ready to participate.

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1. Autor and Thompson use the example of accounting clerks versus inventory clerks to motivate their framework. What happened to wages and employment in each case, and why did the outcomes differ?
2. What is the "expertise framework," and how does it differ from simply measuring education levels?
3. The authors reference "Polanyi's paradox." What is it, and why do they argue AI overcomes it?
4. The essay outlines two future scenarios. Briefly describe the more optimistic one and the more pessimistic one.
5. Pick one claim or policy proposal from the essay that you found either compelling or unconvincing. State it in one sentence, then say why you reacted the way you did.